My Red Hand, My Black Hand

By Dael Orlandersmith

CHARACTERS
DAUGHTER: *Indian and black, aged late teens to mid-twenties.*
FATHER: *Native American, late fifties to mid-sixties.*
MOTHER: *Black, late fifties to mid-sixties.*

NOTE: The reference in the script "boom, boom, boom boom!" should be spoken like the John Lee Hooker song "Boom, Boom!" Listen on YouTube at https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=X70VMrH3yBg *The other reference, "Gonna shoot it right down," also should be spoken/performed in the spirit of the song.*

Note that "sport highheeled shoes" and "sporting high-heeled shoes" are references to Chuck Berry's song "Sweet Little Sixteen." Listen on You Tube at https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZLV4NGpoy_E

INTRODUCTION

This story is of one girl's courageous search for belonging and acceptance in the two very distinct cultures that make up her heritage—African American and Native American

She tells us about the "Red" Tlingit and Lakota parentage of her father, who leaves the reservation to play blues rock in Boston . . . And the "Black" rural Virginia Background of her mother, who goes to Boston seeking the big-city life. Her parents meet at a dance and fall in love, but not without the complications of prejudice from their families

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DAUGHTER: My hands/ red/ black
Dance to Rhythms
Different / Various / similar rhythms

My Red Hand it dances to the
Rhythm of my Father's Blood I His Blood Beat / His
red
Man beat
PURE REDMAN

FATHER: My father/ his mother/

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Tlingit from Alaska /

DAUGHTER: Died giving birth to him
She died/
But she still whispered to him /
My father / his father

FATHER: Santee Lakota

DAUGHTER: My father half Tlingit
Half Lakota dreamer

FATHER: Transported
Transported
to Boston

DAUGHTER: He/ my Father crying for his
Father / Drumming up the
Rhythm of his Father Through
Pent up Angers
Wearing Eagle Feathers

FATHER: Sign of the Eagle

DAUGHTER: Sign of Scorpio-Nov. 4 / His birthday
My Father/

FATHER: Eagle Born

DAUGHTER: Scorpion
beat his
hands to the rhythm of
his Father's Ghost

FATHER: His Father/ My Grandfather
Spent
Depleted
American Dreams / Stomped into the
Dirt of the Res /

DAUGHTER: His American
Dream/

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FATHER: to pick up
a Guitar
To be a Blues Man
To be a Red Man / Blues Man-

DAUGHTER: My Father's Father/ My Grandfather

FATHER: Ghost danced Lakota Style

DAUGHTER: to
his father / my Great Grandfather's rhythm
but he closed his eyes and also
Ghost dances with

FATHER: Robert Johnson /
Mississippi John Hurt
Blind Lemon Jefferson

DAUGHTER: He/ my Grandfather couldn't leave it/

FATHER: The Res-

DAUGHTER: They wouldn't let him leave it/
The Res/

FATHER: -"you're not True to
your own"

DAUGHTER: -they said

FATHER: "you're not proud to
be a red man"

DAUGHTER: they said-

FATHER: "If you leave/ Don't come
back/

DAUGHTER: Don't come back
to the Res"-they say

He / my Grandfather Looked
into my Father's Eagle eyes

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A Child's eyes / knowing
eyes / an old child's eyes /
His eyes - my Grandfather's eyes
Said

FATHER: "Take the world/ make
it yours / Rock the world
You can Rock

DAUGHTER: Rock

FATHER: Rock

FATHER/DAUGHTER: Rock the World"

DAUGHTER: My Father Glides Eagle-eyed from the
Res and the Tlingit island /

FATHER: Leather-jacketed /Eagle-
eyed/

DAUGHTER: Blues and Tlingit **/** Lakota riffs
dripping from his fingers /

FATHER: Chuck Berry /

DAUGHTER: Tlingit riffs
dripping from his fingers /
Leather-jacketed and Guitar ready
Just like Chuck Berry or

FATHER: Link Wray

DAUGHTER: -Link Wray

FATHER: -a Shawnee
from North Carolina

DAUGHTER: -A RED / Blues
Rock 'n' Roll man /

FATHER: -a cool man

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DAUGHTER: My Father cool -Just like Link Wray

FATHER: Slick

DAUGHTER: -Just like Link Wray
Ghost dances Lakota Style / Tlingit Style
and Rock 'n' Rolled / a Steady
Rock 'n' Roll bop

and Somebody on the Res says
"How could you do that / Leave /
us / How could you? /
You're not proud of your own
kind" / Somebody on the Res says /
they say "wanna be a white
boy? / Wait till they call you a FeatherHead" /
Someone on the Res says

My Father stares straight ahead

FATHER: Eagle-eyed /

DAUGHTER: proud and
Eagle-eyed
Outside

FATHER: --Standing Tall

DAUGHTER: Inside-Rumbling
The voices of the Res rumbled /
inside of him but he continued to
dance/

FATHER: Ghost dance/

DAUGHTER: The Res voices Got Louder/
He continued to Blues dance /
Blues / Red / Blues / John Lee
Hooker dance / he had to
take the voices and shoot them
down / Vodka
Tequila

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Bourbon
Hide himself in a woman's
Skirt / to kill the voices
Vodka
Tequila
Bourbon
Another woman's skirt / gonna shoot
it right
Down!
My Black Hand-

My Mother's hand / A Black Girl

MOTHER: Girl from Virginia/ my mother/
a
Sharecropper Black Girl from Virginia /

DAUGHTER: Her mother/ my Grandmother
Lynched/

MOTHER: it is Hard Time Virginia /

DAUGHTER: no
Different from Hard Time Mississippi

MOTHER: "Don't walk anywhere
except in Dark Town"

DAUGHTER: they told my
mother

MOTHER: "Just stay in Dark Town"

DAUGHTER: -they told
my mother

MOTHER: "Dark Town" was where the
Dark people lived

DAUGHTER: they
weren't Black Then
They were colored then

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and where they lived was
"Dark Town"

My Mother / Sharecropper Black Girl / Big Black Girl
Knew about Trees

MOTHER: Knew about the Bodies that hung from those trees

DAUGHTER: and the people who wore billowing white sheets
My mother's bare feet

MOTHER: were blistered
from Tar and Dirt Roads /

DAUGHTER: Those feet Shifted themselves

MOTHER: into high heels/

DAUGHTER: She wanted to Chuck Berry Bop
in her high heels /
She wanted

MOTHER: to "Sport high-heeled shoes"

DAUGHTER: She wanted

MOTHER: her hair slicked back
pressed and curled /

DAUGHTER: She wanted

MOTHER: to Lip Balm
her lips-"Ruby" Red Just Like
The Ray Charles Song /

DAUGHTER: She wanted

MOTHER: to snap her fingers/
Slick headed and curly sporting
high-heeled Shoes to the

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rhythm of cities /

DAUGHTER: She wanted to Enter a
New Rhythm
Explore
MOTHER: -not just the
Rhythm of Southern men
Clinging to Mojo /

MOTHER/DAUGHTER: She wanted a city

DAUGHTER: She leaves Dark Town
Slick / curly headed
high heels and fingers snapping and
clicking/
She goes to Boston /
sporting high-heeled shoes

FATHER/MOTHER: There are Dances/
DAUGHTER: yes
There are Dances
People will always Dance

My Father sees her /
He sees her at a dance /
His Eagle eyes / connect to
her Brown / Black Girl Eyes

FATHER: Eagle-eyed RED man/

MOTHER: red-lipped high-heeled Black Girl

DAUGHTER: The Hucklebuck Dance
meets
The Ghost Dance

And the Colored People / Before
They were Black / The
Colored people said

MOTHER: -"Whachoo doin'
with him / Some Red Man /

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What do you want with him /
Some Red Man / That FeatherHead
dancer / whachoo doin'
with him"

DAUGHTER: And the Skins on the Res
said

FATHER: -"You didn't get
an Indian Girl / one of our
Girls / Got a Dark /
Darker/ NIGGER Girl/ not
a Girl from the Res /
What are you doing with her /
Why didn't you Get a Girl
From the Res! /
Come back to the Res!"/

DAUGHTER: They -- my Father
my Mother

They both hear the voices /

FATHER: Voices from the Res/

DAUGHTER: The Tlingit Voice that whispers in his ear

MOTHER: Voices from the Virginia Fields

DAUGHTER: They—both--my Mother and Father
try to Ghost Dance / Blues Dance
Drink away the
Voices

FATHER: --Western/ Northern Red voices/

MOTHER: Southern Black voices

DAUGHTER: They dance
Snap their fingers
Guitar Lick / try to
Shoot it on Down

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FATHER: Vodka
MOTHER: Tequila
DAUGHTER: Bourbon
They try to shoot the voices down /
FATHER: Boom
DAUGHTER: Boom
MOTHER: Boom

DAUGHTER: Boom /
Shoot them all Down-
A year later-they marry-
A year after that
I crash through amniotic Fluid
and blood/
I crash but
silently my mother says

MOTHER: --"She's so quiet"/
DAUGHTER: my Mother says
FATHER: --"Makes no noise"'
DAUGHTER: my Father says
I hear his voice but rarely-him / he usually
Speaks through guitar fingers / his fingers speak
on his guitar I see him /
longhaired / this man/ red man who just spoke /
my father-this red man
this big red man / beautiful man
I am a part of him
My Father
I hear him
But
I can't speak But I can hear
I can't explain/ I'm a baby
But I feel it
I feel them

Turning on themselves
Turning on each other
not always with words
There's looks

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MOTHER: shrugs
FATHER: silence
MOTHER/FATHER: more silence/

DAUGHTER: I feel it/
I feel them
Shooting Themselves
Down-

FATHER: Boom
MOTHER: Boom
FATHER: Boom
MOTHER: Boom

DAUGHTER: Later I'm a child
not a baby / a child
I see it / smell it

FATHER: Vodka
MOTHER: Tequila
DAUGHTER: Bourbon

I hear it my Mother's
Black Southern voice slurry / shot-down voice

MOTHER: I love
him / He's my husband /
my man/ I'm
NEVER Gonna Leave / I love him!

DAUGHTER: The Black Southern/ voices /the
voices are now Black from
the Virginia Fields / The 1960s
and the voices are now Black
tell her / my Mother

MOTHER: -- "your child
is a Nigger / FeatherHead / a Nigger Feather-
Head" --

DAUGHTER: My Mother/ she Vodka
MOTHER: Tequila

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DAUGHTER: Bourbon
MOTHER/DAUGHTER: Cries

DAUGHTER: I hear it in my
Father's voice-more so
in his fingers / Fingers
sliding up and down his guitar
Vodka
Tequila
Bourbon crying

FATHER: Lakota/ Tlingit guitar / Blues a shot-down
Red
Blues
Bruised
Man

DAUGHTER: His voice thundered/
sometimes there was thunder in his voice

FATHER: "She's my wife/ I love her/
Never Gonna give her up/
I love her!"

DAUGHTER: I grow up-my body
can make a
child
I Do not but I can-make a child

A child / a life / can come through me
can come crashing through amniotic
Fluid and Blood /
It can come silently
It can come thunderously

My Grandfather / Long Dead
Ghost dances in the hills /
His wife / my Grandmother
calls me -- "Dark Girl
Monkey Girl

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animal/ Dark/ Monkey
Girl!/ The
elders don't want you /
WE don't want you!" She says /
my Grandmother says
My cousins on my mother's side /
My Black hand side says-

MOTHER: "You're Black/ what's this
Indian / no such thing as
HALF BLACK!"

DAUGHTER: They/ my cousins/ my Black hand
mother side cousins say put
down my Father's Tlingit walk / Ghost dance /
put aside sweet guitar licks and
the Red / Blues of my
Grandfather / Put aside
his slick / sleek
Rock 'n' Roll res/ Boston Bop/
Put it Down/
Shoot in on
Down

My Red hand / my Father's
hand / His mother / my
Grandmother / cousins
Don't call my name
I'm the "dark"/ Monkey Girl/
Don't have a name-
An uncle / he calls my name /
says my name/
only him / my Father's Brother /
my uncle / he says

FATHER: "Drop the
Black Blood / walk like a
Skin / Drop the Dark / Darkey
walk / You're a SKIN"

DAUGHTER: How can I drop the

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walk of Southern Black
Girls / the walk heated / hip
walk of Southern high-heeled Black
Girls

MOTHER: *(repeating)* You're Black/ no such thing as HALF
BLACK

FATHER: *(repeating)* Walk like a Skin

DAUGHTER: I answer to the voices
I answer to the voices in
Dark Town/
I answer to the voices in
Black Town / The Town where
Black people live
I answer to the voices My Grandmother's Tlingit voice
That whispers in my ear
I see / dance with my Grandfather /
We sing a Red man Blues
I am Tlingit / Lakota and Blues
I am an electric slider / Tlingit / Lakota Ghost Dancer
I've got Red / Black hands

I answer to all the voices

I know that Blind Lemon Jefferson
did the Ghost dance with Robert Johnson
and Robert Johnson before
selling his soul to the
devil pulled out the
Mojo and gave it to my
Grandfather who kissed it
and passed it on to my Father who
passed it to me -- I've got Red / Black hands

Don't tell me not to Ghost
dance on the Res
Call for my ancestors
on the Res/
whisper Tlingit secrets to my Grandmother /
dance/ Link Wray style

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Down at the Res I
I will rock the Res

I've got
FATHER: Red /
MOTHER: Black
DAUGHTER: hands
Don't anybody expect me to
Shoot it
Shoot
Shoot
it
on Down

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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